Grey

Calm · neutrality · distance

Grey can recall a stone by a river, a soft jumper, morning mist and an office in which someone was clearly afraid to buy anything colourful. At times it is elegant and pleasant. At others you feel that joy has moved out of the room and forgotten to leave a forwarding address. Are you looking for calm in it, or is something already missing for you in it?

This page does not tell you what grey means. **It shows it to you from several sides**. How it is mixed, how it is painted with, where its reputation comes from, how it is read in different cultures and **what it can awaken in us**.

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How to mix the colour and its shades

One grey? More like a large family. You can grade grey from almost white to almost black. In commonly called greys you also often find a tinge of blue, green, pink or beige.

On the palette it looks neutral, but next to a warm beige it suddenly looks bluish and next to another grey it may show a pink tinge. **Its look is influenced by light and neighbouring colours.** Make a sample and hold several colours up to it. Sometimes you do not need to change the grey itself, but the company in which you placed it.

What to prepare



White

The base of light greys.



Black

For simple grey mixtures and darkening.



Blue

For cooler, steely and bluish shades.



Sienna or orange

With blue it makes muted mixtures close to grey.



Ochre or brown

For warmer, stony and grey-beige tones.



Red or magenta

A small amount shifts grey to a pink or purple tinge.

How can you recognise it without technical names?

The simplest grey is mixed from white and black. **It is not the only way, though.** You can also get it by muting complementary colours against each other, for example blue and orange. Depending on the pigments the mixture may at first come out brown or tilted to one colour side.

For light mixtures start with white. **Black can take the lead faster** than its size on the palette would suggest.

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What the additions do



White

Lightens. Add black by the tip, not the other way round.





Black

Darkens and cools. It can take over the whole mixture, add by the drop.





Blue

Shifts toward steely and cold. A tiny dose is enough.





Sienna

Mutes blue into a quiet grey-brown tone. Add gradually.





Ochre

Shifts toward warm, stony and sandy.





Magenta

Shifts toward a pink and purple tinge. Only the tip of the brush.



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Ten greys to try

A part can be a drop, or an equally big heap of paint. The strength of pigments differs, so **take the ratios as a starting point for trying**.

Light grey



10 parts white and a really small addition of black. Light and soft.

Mid grey



Gradually add black into white according to the lightness required. Balanced and calm.

Anthracite



Black and a small amount of white, possibly a trace of blue. Deep and firm.

Blue-grey



White, a little blue and a tiny trace of orange to mute it. Cool and airy.

Warm stone



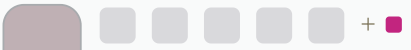
Light grey and a trace of ochre or brown. Soft and natural.

Grey-beige



White and a little brown, according to the result a trace of blue. Calm and homely.

Soft pink-grey



Light grey and a tiny bit of magenta or a cooler red. Tender and muted.

Violet-grey



White, purple and a very small amount of yellow. Dreamy and quiet.

Grey from colours



Adjust blue and burnt sienna into a muted mixture, then add white. Livelier than black and white.

Green-grey



Light grey and a tiny trace of green. Misty and fresh.

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Rainbow – the chakra system

Grey has **no stripe of its own** in the rainbow. Neutral grey is among the achromatic colours, it has no colour hue like green or red. In the basic seven-colour chakra map it has no place of its own either, so here we read it as **a background** on which colours stand out more easily.

The whole rainbow as a map of questions



Red · root

Support, safety, presence. Ask yourself. What can I lean on?



Yellow · solar plexus

Self-worth, will, decision-making. Ask yourself. What do I want to choose for myself?



Blue · throat

Voice, expression, communication. Ask yourself. What do I need to say?



Violet · crown

Transcendence, meaning, connection. Ask yourself. What gives me a wider sense of meaning?



Orange · sacral

Experiencing, pleasure, sensuality. Ask yourself. What does me good?



Green · heart

Closeness, kindness, relationships. Ask yourself. Where can I be open and still stay with myself?



Indigo · third eye

Inner vision, intuition, discernment. Ask yourself. What is beginning to dawn on me?



Grey · no chakra of its own

The space between colours. Ask yourself. What will I start to notice when I take a little away around me?

Grey as a ground for your own perception

Imagine a table full of coloured fabrics. When you lay them all tightly side by side, you may not know where to look. **A grey ground can give them room to stand out.** Similarly, sometimes you need a moment without another offer, opinion or demand. That is our comparison, not an energetic property prescribed to grey.

Some spiritual interpretations attribute blockages or lack of energy to grey. Liking grey alone proves nothing of the kind. **Chakras come from the Indian yogic and tantric tradition** and grey does not belong to them in the classical form.

When grey does you good. It is pleasant that nothing shouts. You can calmly notice what you really want and you do not have to show off.

When grey does not do you good. Everything blends together, you miss liveliness or you feel you are getting lost. These are not proofs of the state of a chakra, they are situations in which you can get to know yourself.

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How to use grey when you lack calm

- **Lay it in front of you**
  Grey paper or fabric on a table. Hold several coloured pieces against it and look for a while.
- **Put it on**
  A soft grey jumper after a day among people. You put down demands, not just work clothes.
- **Put it in your hand**
  A smooth grey pebble or silver jewellery. The touch stops you for a moment and brings you back into the room.
- **Put it in a room**
  A warm light grey on bedding or a wall. Watch it in the morning and in the evening.
- **Paint it**
  Mist, stone and gentle transitions. Without a goal and without judging.
- **Give yourself less today**
  Choose one place at home and leave on it only what you are currently doing.

When you already miss the company of colours in grey

First leave room for the feeling. Only then can you invite symbolic themes. The choice of colour does not determine which chakra you have closed. It can help you find a theme to which you want to give attention. **You do not need more grey.** You need to invite other colours.

- **Add red**
  Do I need more support? Lipstick, a scarf or a firm step.
- **Add orange**
  Am I missing pleasure? A mug that makes you laugh.
- **Add yellow**
  Do I need to decide on my own? Something you chose today.
- **Add green or pink**
  Do I want closeness or care? A plant, a flower, a soft fabric.

This is inspiration from tradition, not treatment. Try gently and notice how you actually feel afterwards.

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Picture it with an example

All day somebody wants something, screens flash and at home you long for a surrounding that announces nothing more. A grey jumper can be comfortable. A grey room clear. **It need not be a secret message about your soul.** At other times the chance to disappear a little may attract you. Do I feel freer in grey, or am I mainly trying not to be in the way? The answer cannot be read off the colour.

Next to grey other colours can stand out. Yellow lights up, red strengthens and green recalls leaves in mist. **These are possibilities for personal reading**, not effects prescribed by a colour combination.

How to use this map

It is a way to sort out the themes you are living through. If grey gives you a pleasant calm, it can stay. If you miss liveliness next to it, try another pairing. **You choose the meaning.**

Grey has no place in the classical seven-colour map, not even an eighth.

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Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, without a goal and without trying to make a pretty picture, we often reach for grey when we want **silence and distance**, or when we are already **too tired of colours**. But we do not always know why. Sometimes we know exactly, sometimes not at all. Both are fine.

What may hide behind a grey stroke

The same grey area on paper can mean **something completely different each time**, depending on what is going on in us. That is why it makes no sense to read a picture like a test with a single right answer.

Calm.

Soft grey areas without sharp edges. A wish that nothing demand attention.

Mist.

Light translucent layers that blend together. Something that does not want to show itself yet.

Stone.

Dense darker strokes, often at the bottom beneath the other colours. A firmness that nothing upsets.

Distance.

Grey between two coloured areas. A space that separates and at the same time protects.

Tiredness.

Dull grey areas without light. A feeling that there has been enough.

Elegance.

Soft transitions from light to dark, precise lines. Joy in simplicity.

Grey in a picture. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, it **can**, but it **does not have to**. A grey picture need not be a sad picture. You can find in it mist, stone, softness, silence or strength. Also tiredness or emptiness. From the amount of grey one cannot tell whether you are sad or "blocked". Equally it can simply be **the colour that was at hand**.

When painting you do not have to look for an explanation. Let your hand work. You can return to what appeared later. It gains meaning only in connection with **your experience**.

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I want it on the canvas, but I don't dare put it on myself

A picture and a dress ask two completely different things of you. Perhaps you chose a grey coat because "nobody will comment on that one at least". If nobody were judging me in it, would I choose the same? The answer may well be yes. **Grey need not be questioned just because it is not conspicuous.**

If you like wearing it but do not want to blend in, you do not need to discard half your wardrobe. Try one change. Add to a grey base bigger earrings, a rich scarf or coloured shoes. Combine light and dark, smooth and textured material. Others also notice your voice, movement, expression and way of dealing with people.

Grey will not take your words from you. But a coloured scarf will not start a conversation for you either.

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When grey takes over the space

First, let your hand work. **A grey picture does not have to be cheered up by anyone.** Who actually decided that a picture needs extra colour? Before you reach for yellow, try to notice whether you want it. Or whether you are just now correcting the picture according to someone else's idea of how joy should look.

Three things worth noticing

- **QUANTITY**

Relief, or loss?

A large grey area can pleasantly tie a picture together. At other times it starts to cover everything that was alive in it. Perhaps it is just covering that you want to try and you need not rescue the picture with colour at once. When you want, notice whether you feel good in that area, or feel like making a gap or opening a space.

- **LIGHTNESS**

Mist, or a concrete wall?

A light translucent grey feels different from a dense anthracite. The difference is made by the shade, the amount of paint and the way it is applied. When everything blends for you, try a lighter and a darker grey side by side. When it feels cold, hold ochre, a warm pink or brown against it and compare the impression.

- **THICKNESS**

Painting can be alive even without bright colours

A thin layer can let something show through. A dense one you can press down, push aside or scratch a mark into. If you want something new to appear, let the ground show through or add a colour that attracts you.

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What to take from the picture

It does not matter what a grey stroke looks like. What matters is what you feel while making it and what is going on in your life at that moment. **Two identical pictures can have a completely different meaning**. One arose in a feeling of calm, the other after a day when you wanted to hide. That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but **questions**.

A picture can speak even after time

After a time you may see that grey gave you calm then. Or it will recall a period when you wanted to hide. In self-reflection inspired by art therapy you link a picture with your own memories. The colour alone will not tell the story for you.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at what you have painted and it tells you nothing. In a week, a month or a year, though, it may suddenly dawn on you. That is fine. **The painting will wait until you are ready to understand it.**

If very strong or painful feelings appear while painting, do not stay alone with them. Talk about them with someone close or with a therapist. This page does not replace professional care.

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Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list "grey = this", and yet they tend to be surprisingly similar. They are usually made of three layers: **the body**, **culture** and **what we ourselves have lived through**.

From the body

Grey is the colour of **mist, stone, ash and animal fur**. It is the colour of things that recede or, on the contrary, quietly hold. That is why we perceive it as **neutral**, sometimes calm, sometimes cool.

From culture

In Europe grey was long linked with **offices, the city and the everyday**. But at the same time also with elegance and influence. Phrases like grey mouse, grey eminence or grey drabness each carry a different meaning. We will look at this in more detail in the chapter on cultures.

From what you have lived

The fur of an animal you like to touch, a peeling corridor where you waited for unpleasant news, a stone in the sun, a favourite jumper or a November city in which you were alone. These memories decide the most. **The same colour label, a completely different experience.**

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is really "grey" and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What does grey connect with first for me, and where do I know it from?**

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Stories

Grey has several stories worth untangling. They show where the colour ends and where what people make of it begins.

A picture only in grey, grisaille

Grisaille is painting done exclusively in shades of black and grey, sometimes with a narrower range of colour. It was used **to imitate sculpture** in large decorations, as an underpainting for oil pictures where colour was added only later, and as a model for engravers. It was also quicker and cheaper than full colour, although sometimes it was chosen for aesthetic reasons too.

Giotto used it in the lower parts of the frescoes in the Scrovegni Chapel in Padua around **1304**. Pieter Bruegel the Elder painted Christ and the woman taken in adultery in grey tone in 1565. Grey here is not a lack of colour. It is **a decision to let light, shadow and volume speak for themselves**.

The Cistercians and the year 1134

In **1134** the Cistercians banned coloured art in their monasteries. The roots of grey stained glass, so-called grisaille, reach, according to an overview, to the twelfth century and to Cistercian monasteries. Grey glass let light through without bright colours.

Today grey in a church may seem cold to you. For monks it may have been a guarantee that nothing disturbs the light and prayer. The same colour, a different reason.

Grey eminence

Originally the name belonged to François Leclerc du Tremblay, known as **Père Joseph**, the right hand of Cardinal Richelieu, who in effect ruled France. Joseph was a Capuchin and wore their grey habit. More interesting than the colour itself was the contrast with Richelieu's bright red cardinal's robe.

He was never a cardinal, but around him he was called "eminence" because he stood so close to power. Today the word denotes a person with great influence who stands in the background. Grey here does not mean inconspicuousness. It means **influence that does not show itself**.

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Emotions and feelings

The same grey can evoke **calm** in one of us and **emptiness** in another, sometimes even both in one day. There is no single fixed effect. It depends on our body, experience, culture and situation.

Emotions

Quick and strong reactions that can appear even before you realise them.

Calm

A feeling that **nothing shouts** and you do not have to show off.

And why?

Grey is a colour without sharp stimuli. After a day when everyone wanted something from you it can be a relief. A neutral surrounding lets you and what you are doing stand out.

Ask yourself

"When did I last feel truly calm?"

Relief

A feeling that you can **put down demands** along with work clothes.

And why?

After a day among people it can be pleasant to change into simple soft clothes. The benefit lies in the whole transition, you put down clothes, demands and the need to make some impression. Grey can accompany this moment if you link it with comfort.

And what if I asked you now?

"What can I put down today?"

Distance

A wish to keep **a little aside** and look from above.

And why?

Grey does not raise its voice. It can give you room to observe and not to decide at once. Just watch whether it is a distance that helps you, or a wall that separates you from people.

And try answering now

"What do I need to withdraw from for a while now?"

Boredom

A feeling that **everything repeats anyway** and nothing moves.

And why?

Grey phrases, like grey drabness, add to the colour a meaning that belongs to the life around it. A surrounding without change and without light naturally becomes tiresome. Grey need not be to blame.

And now one question for you

"What would bring me a small change today?"

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Feelings and experience

Deeper and slower states that settle in us. You often recognise them only after a while.

Privacy

A feeling that **you do not have to be in view** and need not explain anything.

And why?

When you have had enough stimuli, you long for a surrounding that announces nothing more. A grey jumper or room can be clear. At other times the chance to disappear a little may attract you. Both are fine.

Ask yourself

"Where do I allow myself to be unobserved, and am I well there?"

Simplicity

Joy in **fewer things** competing for attention.

And why?

By experience, a smaller number of things can free the head. Grey here serves as a neutral ground. But take care that simplicity does not become the removal of what you love.

And what if I asked you now?

"Does simplicity help me, or did I remove even what I love?"

Dulling

A feeling that everything **has gone quiet and grey**.

And why?

In research on colour associations grey is linked with sadness. A link in the imagination, though, is not proof that a grey room saddens everyone. If the dulling lasts long, or takes away your joy in ordinary things, talk to someone close or to a professional.

And try answering now

"Is it a grey day, or has something in me not moved for a long time?"

Loneliness

A feeling that **it is cold around you** and nobody is looking.

And why?

A grey city, a grey corridor and a grey wall can evoke a sense of absence of others. It helps to notice whether it is the colour, or also noise, emptiness and missing people. Sometimes you need quiet. At other times a person with whom you need not be alone in that quiet.

And now one question for you

"Who could I be at peace with today?"

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My grey is not the same as your grey

The colour itself **experiences nothing**. We experience it. When we first see a colour together with something strong (a smell, a face, a situation, a word), the **experience** sticks to it. The colour then becomes a **shortcut**. That is why **your own reaction** is the most important.

- **Grey coat**
  For one elegance, for another hiding.
- **Grey room**
  For one clarity, for another a catalogue where she does not want to live.
- **Grey city**
  For one calm and architecture, for another concrete and loneliness.
- **Grey hair**
  For one relief from dyeing, for another a change she does not want yet.
- **Grey stone**
  For one a touch that stops, for another a thing on the way.

Why does it attract me right now?

Perhaps you have had enough stimuli. All day somebody wants something and at home you long for surroundings that announce nothing more. A grey jumper can be comfortable. **It need not be a secret message about your soul.**

When I see grey on someone else

You meet a woman who always walks around in grey. What occurs to you? Is she inconspicuous, elegant, tired? The first impression comes quickly, but the story you add to it need not belong to that woman. Try splitting your impression into three things. What I see, say a grey coat and a simple cut. How it affects me, say calmly or sternly. And what I infer, say that she is reserved. **The first point describes the clothing, the second your experience, the third already ascribes traits to a person.**

When to keep it and when to take some away

Keep it when you feel good beside it and do not have to talk yourself into a pleasant impression. Take away when the whole seems cold, blurring or foreign. First try one change. Add a flower, a picture, a coloured fabric or ceramics. Then notice whether the change pleases you even after the first enthusiasm. **Sometimes it is not colour you lack, but rest or company.**

Ask yourself

“Which sentence about grey is loudest in me? Whose is it, actually?”

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Grey in cultures and traditions

Grey is a colour people long thought of as "without meaning". Stone, mist, metal. Behind its reputation, though, are **more stories about craft, faith and power than about the colour itself**. Let us visit a few places and read them carefully.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how grey is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image, not as instructions. What is verified history and what is later interpretation, I say in each part.

Grey in different cultures

Japan

In the Edo period the shogunate restricted luxury for people outside the ruling class. The outer layers of clothing could only be in muted grey, brown and navy. According to an exhibition at the Honolulu museum there were **over a hundred variants** of these shades.

The restriction became a game. The people of Edo wore colourful patterned fabrics on linings and underwear and on visible layers they invented stripes.

Grey here is not a lack. It is **the colour of a taste that does not need to show itself**.

China

Chinese ink painting, shuimo hua, arose under the Tang dynasty (618 to 907) and flourished under the Song dynasty (960 to 1279). A painter can pass from a single brush stroke from deep black to silvery grey, depending on how thickly the ink was spread and how hard he pressed.

This style reached Japan in the fourteenth century through Zen monasteries. Zen links it with calm and simplicity.

Grey here is not what is left of colour. It is **a whole scale from which a landscape is born**.

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Iceland

Icelandic sheep are born black, grey, brown and white and undyed wool in these shades is in demand. From wool called lopi, lopapeysa jumpers are knitted. According to the knitting historian Annemor Sundbø the pattern is related to a 1930 model and after 1944, when Iceland gained full independence, it became a national symbol.

From Nordic cold, where grey is not a restriction but the natural colour of an animal.

A colour can be **a material that does not need dyeing** to be valuable.

Peru

The Incas built their most sacred structures, such as the Temple of the Sun at Machu Picchu, from precisely cut stones that fitted together without mortar. The walls sloped slightly inward and had rounded corners, and therefore resisted earthquakes well. In strong tremors the blocks, as described, "danced" and then returned to place.

From architecture that reckons with the earth moving.

Grey here is not dead. It is **stone that has learned to stand in motion**.

Grey in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at grey **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and an inspiration, not a healing manual.

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Traditional Chinese medicine

In the classical system of five elements white is linked mainly with metal. **Grey has no organ circuit of its own.** In some extended colour interpretations it comes close to metal through the look of metallic materials and its kinship with white. In the traditional metal circuit autumn, lungs, large intestine and grief meet. These are connections within a traditional system, not a guide to determining health by clothing.

How it relates to grey. Autumn can offer an image of discernment. What to keep and what you no longer need to carry. Perhaps you have at home things you did not choose, tasks nobody else took over, and ideas about yourself that long ago stopped fitting. You do not have to throw everything out. **You can start with one place.**

And what if I asked you now?

“What do I need to put down today to make more room?”

A grey base on the table

Try a simple grey base on the table and keep on it only what you are currently doing. The benefit can be fewer things competing for attention.

In grief

A surrounding that does not ask for a cheerful expression may feel pleasant. Grey can accompany this need. You do not have to get orange curtains just to show that you are "moving on". But notice the difference between pleasant privacy and a surrounding in which you feel increasingly lonely.

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. It describes a person by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are not assigned to the doshas uniformly in the classical texts, so here you read **modern interpretations**, not an old table.

How it relates to grey. Ayurvedic thinking works with the qualities of warmth and cold, lightness and heaviness or movement and stability. Grey, though, is not always equally cold or heavy. A soft woollen blanket and a glossy metal chair may be a similar colour and have a completely different relation to your comfort.

Pitta

This describes a woman who is purposeful, quick and thorough, who flares up easily. A light, cooler grey can feel cooling and calming. Glossy metal and sharp contrast may, on the contrary, irritate.

- **Dove and silver**
  Light and cooling, as a base.
- **Beware of sharp contrast**
  Black with glossy metal can be one more stimulus.

Vata

This describes a woman who is imaginative and quick, but restless and often cold. A warmer grey-beige and soft fabrics can add warmth. **It is best to notice how you really feel in it.**

- **Grey-beige and wool**
  Warm and soft, without chill.
- **Evening and sleep**
  Soft textiles and warm light.

Kapha

This describes a woman who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily grows heavy. Large dark grey areas can deepen the heaviness, so give them **a lively and light companion**.

- **Light wood and colour**
  A fresh counterweight.
- **Add movement**
  Yellow or orange as an accent. A scarf, a tablecloth.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

Jung did not describe grey as a colour of its own. What I write next is my own reflection in the spirit of his thinking, not his statement.

How it relates to grey. Grey lies between white and black, that is, between light and dark. In symbolic language you can read it as **the colour of the threshold and of the space between two poles**. When you think about it, ask where you stand between two possibilities and whether that threshold serves you.

What you can take from it. Jung did not want colours turned into a dictionary. **We always ask what it means for you.** The same grey can be calm for one woman and coldness for another. Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic frame, not verified science.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging space so that it is good to live in. In some contemporary schools grey belongs to metal and the themes of clarity, lucidity and order. Schools differ in the assignments, so take it as one possibility.

Grey is like silver

A little gives a space clarity, a whole room turns it into a catalogue. Order is not the number of grey things.

Simple tips

- **Start with a question**
  Does simplicity help me, or did I remove from the room even what I love? The difference is often in the light.
- **Try a warmer fabric**
  A soft throw or a linen cushion softens a cold impression better than another grey decoration.
- **Vary the surfaces**
  Smooth and textured grey work together better than five identical surfaces.
- **Add light**
  Grey without daylight feels empty. Draw back the curtains and let the light in.
- **Watch the undertones**
  Warm grey-beige and cold blue-grey sometimes understand each other less than their shared name promised.
- **Try textiles first**
  Before you repaint a room, try a throw or a larger sample and look at it both in the morning and in the evening.

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What people say and what holds true

MYTH Grey is dull.

TRUTH Photographers use a grey card with 18 percent reflectance as a reference for exposure and white balance. Grey is there actually a fixed point.

MYTH Grey always calms.

TRUTH Warm grey does. Cold grey without daylight can feel oppressive. Wood, linen or one warm colour will help.

MYTH Grey goes with everything.

TRUTH Mostly yes, but it depends on the undertone. A bluish grey next to warm wood can be cold. Hold a sample against your things and look at it in daylight.

What grey goes well with

- **Wood, ochre and terracotta**
  A warmer, earthier impression.
- **Pink**
  Softness or striking contrast depending on the shade.
- **Yellow**
  A conspicuous light accent.
- **Green**
  A pairing recalling leaves and stone.
- **Blue**
  A cooler whole. Watch the light and the amount of both colours.
- **White and black**
  More pronounced differences between surfaces.

Elements

- **Metal**
  Grey is its natural stand-in. Make sure it does not outweigh.
- **Earth**
  Ochre and stone warm it up.
- **Wood**
  Green and wood enliven it.
- **Fire**
  Warm light and a small red accent heat it up.

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Feng shui room by room

Living room

What works. A grey sofa can let a picture, wood, plants or a favourite textile stand out.

What to watch for. When the floor, wall, sofa and curtains are all grey, the individual parts blend, especially in a room with little light.

A simple tip. Try a warmer fabric, a lighter surface or a colour you like.

Kitchen and bathroom

What works. Grey cupboards, stone or tiles can feel pleasant.

What to watch for. More glossy grey surfaces and cold light, the result is then austere.

A simple tip. Wood, textiles or coloured ceramics change the reflections and the feel of the materials.

Bedroom

What works. A warm light grey can be pleasant on bedding or a wall. With cream, muted pink or wood it feels softer than blue-grey with metal.

What to watch for. Cold grey and shine. A shade you liked in the shop may look different at home.

A simple tip. If you feel cold, start with textiles and light. You do not have to repaint the whole room at once.

Children's room

What works. A grey base allows easy changing of pictures and textiles.

What to watch for. An adult's taste is not automatically a child's need.

A simple tip. Let the child choose. A room can be tidy and still have an orange dinosaur in it.

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Study

What works. Grey can create an unobtrusive background on which work stands out.

What to watch for. A large dark area can needlessly darken the space. A pleasant shade does not replace a good lamp.

A simple tip. Add something of your own too. A study need not look as if you had rented it together with someone else's life.

Hallway and street

What works. You walk down a street and it seems sad to you. Is it only the grey, or also that there is no tree or bench anywhere and the houses are neglected? A few streets further there may be a stone square, also grey, but with trees and people.

What to watch for. Claiming that a grey city is sad, regardless of light and greenery.

A simple tip. On a walk try to notice two grey places, one pleasant and one you want to get away from. What is different?

And try answering now

"Why do I want grey at home? What should it bring me, calm, clarity, or space for myself?"

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Colour frequency and phototherapy

With grey people talk about "neutral energy" and a "balanced frequency". It sounds as if it had its own number that could be read off. A grey fabric **reflects** light, a grey lamp **emits** light. Let us say what of this is **atmosphere** and what is already **treatment**.

And it is just here that it is good to leave aside **miraculous promises**. A grey wall or a grey filter is not in itself a therapeutic light method.

What frequency does grey have?

Grey does not belong to a single frequency of light. A neutral grey surface under white lighting reflects different parts of visible light roughly evenly, but less light than a white surface. Its look is also affected by the surroundings. That is why a grey jumper cannot be assigned one "photon number" that would explain your mood.

A grey wall and a grey day

On an overcast day you also perceive a change of light, weather and your chances of being outdoors. It does not follow that grey itself causes winter tiredness. If you lack light, deal with light too. Draw back the curtains, let daylight into the room and give yourself time outdoors in the daytime. **A yellow cushion may please the eye, but does not replace daylight.**

When does phototherapy belong to the topic?

Bright light treatment is used, for example, for winter seasonal depression. It works with a specific light and procedure, not with a "healing grey". If in a certain part of the year your mood and everyday functioning repeatedly worsen markedly, **discuss the options with a doctor**. The suitability of light therapy also belongs in that consultation.

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Astrotype and colours

Are you Libra, Sagittarius or Pisces? The astrotype is a much broader topic than just the sun sign. If you really want to go into **depth**, knowing only your date of birth is not enough. The exact place and time of birth are also important, because only from them are the ascendant, the position of the Moon, planets and other parts of the horoscope calculated. Here, though, we stay only at the edge of what relates to colours.

Astrology does not assign grey unambiguously. It is most often linked with Saturn (by tradition lead and stone belong to it), sometimes with the Moon and Mercury in their silvery form. Sources differ here, so take it as inspiration. Depending on how the planet of your sign relates to grey, it may feel close to you, or distant. Find your sign (the dates are approximate and change by year) and read what grey may say to you.

The ascendant is the sign that was rising on the eastern horizon at the moment of your birth. According to astrological tradition it shows how you come across outwardly and how you enter the world, while the Sun sign describes more who you are inside. For each sign you will therefore find not only its character but also a short note on how the colour fits when it is your ascendant.

Aries (21 March – 19 April)

Your grey

graphite · grey · red

A grey that **lets you quieten down without losing**.

Aries is linked with Mars, fire and the start of spring. Grey is for it like the ash after a fire, **calm after the first step**. Graphite next to red may suit you better than a light dove grey.

What Aries is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality cardinal · ruler Mars

Aries opens the zodiac and you can tell that it is first. It is a **pioneer** who gets into things before thinking them through perfectly. It is direct, impatient and likes to compete. It gets angry quickly but forgives quickly too.

Its strength is the **courage** to begin. Weaker is perseverance in long, slow matters. It does best where something is happening and where it can act at once.

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What it can support in you

Grey can support moments when you need to stop and do not feel you are giving way. It fits where a firm head is needed.

With Aries the strength is often in the first step. Graphite can add **deliberation** and take away some pointless haste.

Shadow clenched teeth instead of calm

In the shadow, Aries rejects grey because it carries calm as a defeat. It stays in motion even when stopping would do it good.

Aries fears that if it slowed down, it would lose its lead. So it keeps starting and allows itself rest only when it drops.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **take five minutes of grey silence** and notice that nobody has won over you.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Mars red or black.

red | black | white

Red and black give grey fire so that it is not cold.

Aries as ascendant

When Aries is your ascendant, you come across as direct, lively and decisive. People may see you as someone who gets straight to the point, and the first impression tends to be brisk.

Grey gives you a calmer impression than your tempo suggests. Graphite is the closest.

In everyday life

Take a smooth grey stone in your hand and just hold it for a while.

*When you feel like running further, take **a grey scarf and five minutes at a window**. You do not have to prove anything.*

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Taurus (20 April – 20 May)

Your grey

stone · grey · beige

Grey as **stone, linen and cashmere**.

Taurus is an earth sign linked with Venus, the senses and stability. Grey suits it in warm and soft materials. Cashmere, linen and smooth stone may feel like **luxury without shouting**.

What Taurus is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality fixed · ruler Venus

Taurus is an earthy, **patient** and sensual sign. It likes good food, pleasant materials, nature and security. It gets going slowly, but once it decides on something, it persists.

Its strength is **reliability** and the ability to enjoy the present moment. The weaker side tends to be stubbornness and finding it hard to let go of what is familiar.

What it can support in you

Grey can support the joy of touch and simple things. It fits where you want comfort without ornament.

With Taurus it is often not only about colour but about surface. Warm stone and grey-beige feel completely different from a glossy synthetic.

Shadow stubborn silence

In the shadow, Taurus closes itself in grey silence and does not want to talk about it. Calm turns into a wall that others stand in front of.

Taurus likes certainty and silence gives it that. Only nothing is resolved and the tension returns.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **say one sentence aloud**, even if nobody expects it.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add green and cream.

green · cream · ochre

Green and ochre give grey freshness and warmth.

Taurus as ascendant

When Taurus is your ascendant, you come across as calm, stable and pleasant. You build trust slowly and people often feel firm ground in you.

Grey gives you a calm and trustworthy impression. Warm stone suits more than cold.

In everyday life

Take in your hand something grey that you like and notice how it feels under your fingers.

A grey throw and a good book. ***Treat yourself to them without apology.***

Gemini (21 May – 20 June)

Your grey

dove · blue-grey · silver

A grey that **calms a head full of ideas**.

Gemini is an air sign linked with Mercury, curiosity and speech. Grey suits it as a background on which thoughts stand out. Silver and blue-grey as **paper, a laptop and morning mist**.

What Gemini is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality mutable · ruler Mercury

Gemini is **curious**, talkative and adaptable. It learns quickly, likes to tell stories and enjoys it when a lot is going on around it. It can see several sides of one thing.

Its strength is **lightness** and wit. The weaker side tends to be scatteredness and a tendency to start more things than can be finished.

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What it can support in you

Grey can support moments when you look for room for ideas. It fits a diary, a work desk and a bag.

With Gemini the strength is often in ideas and words. Grey can add **a little silence**.

Shadow I know everything, I experience nothing

In the shadow, Gemini distances itself from its own feelings. Grey becomes the colour of an uninvolved observer.

Gemini likes to understand and grey makes that easier. Only the feelings have no one to be handed to.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **write down one feeling without explaining it**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Mercury yellow or light blue.

yellow | sky blue | white

Yellow and blue add clarity of thought and airiness.

Gemini as ascendant

When Gemini is your ascendant, you come across as lively, friendly and chatty. People may see you as curious and youthful, even if inside you are perhaps calmer.

Grey gives you a calmer and more self-assured impression. Silver and dove are the lightest.

In everyday life

Take a grey notebook and write down in it three things that interested you today.

*When it seems you are only briefly everywhere, give yourself **a moment by a grey wall or stone** and finish one thought to the end.*

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Cancer (21 June – 22 July)

Your grey

dove · pink-grey · silver

Grey as **a quiet mist around home**.

Cancer is a water sign linked with the Moon, home and feeling. Grey may seem to it like a soft blanket. Dove and pink-grey may remind you of **morning mist over water**.

What Cancer is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality cardinal · ruler Moon

Cancer is **caring**, sensitive and strongly connected to home and family. It has a good memory for feelings and relationships. It enters the world cautiously, much like a crab with its shell.

Its strength is **empathy** and the ability to create safety. The weaker side tends to be changeable moods and a tendency to withdraw when it feels hurt.

What it can support in you

Grey can support moments when you need to hide from the world. It fits a house, a bedroom and clothing.

With Cancer the strength is often in empathy. Grey can add **permission for distance**.

Shadow withdrawing into mist

In the shadow, Cancer vanishes into grey so that nobody can hurt it. The home turns into a hiding place.

Cancers fear being hurt and grey offers them hiding. But then nobody knows what they need.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **invite one person for tea** and let them see how you live.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add the Moon's white and silver.

white · silver · cream

White and silver give grey light and openness.

Cancer as ascendant

When Cancer is your ascendant, you come across as gentle and careful. At first you keep your distance, but then warmth unfolds and people see in you someone who will look after them.

Grey gives you a sense of calm and carefulness. Muted and soft shades suit.

In everyday life

In the evening take a grey mug in your hand and sit for a while without tasks.

*When you are tired of watching over everything, take **a grey scarf and remind yourself** that rest belongs to you too.*

Leo (23 July – 22 August)

Your grey

graphite · silver · gold

A grey that **lets you shine without shouting**.

Leo is a fire sign ruled by the Sun. Grey suits it as a frame in which colour and gold show themselves. Graphite and silver as **a jacket that does not drown out what you wear under it**.

What Leo is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality fixed · ruler Sun

Leo is **generous**, proud and creative. It likes to give, likes to rejoice and needs others to see and appreciate it. It is loyal and has a big heart.

Its strength is **warmth** and the ability to inspire others. The weaker side tends to be sensitivity to criticism and a tendency to want to be the centre of attention.

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What it can support in you

Grey can support moments when you want to be seen and at the same time keep calm. It fits an evening, a meeting and a celebration.

With Leo the strength is often in creativity and generosity. Graphite can add **calm dignity**.

Shadow inconspicuousness as a punishment

In the shadow, Leo wears grey because it feels inadequate. It dresses in it so as not to suffer rejection.

Leo needs recognition and grey is safe because it cannot be criticised. Only in it its light stays hidden.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **add one radiant thing** and endure the glances.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add gold or deep blue.

gold · dark blue · red

Gold and dark blue give grey shine and maturity.

Leo as ascendant

When Leo is your ascendant, you come across as self-assured, warm and striking. You enter a room in a way that people notice you even when you do not want them to.

Grey gives you dignity. Graphite and silver suit better than a light dove.

In everyday life

Put on something grey today with one radiant thing.

*When you feel you must shine, take **a grey coat and coloured jewellery**.*

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Virgo (23 August – 22 September)

Your grey

blue-grey · dove · green-grey

Grey as **clean paper and a quiet desk**.

Virgo is an earth sign linked with Mercury, order and care for detail. Grey suits it in clean and precise forms. **Paper, metal and stone** without needless ornament.

What Virgo is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality mutable · ruler Mercury

Virgo is **meticulous**, attentive and practical. It notices details that others overlook and likes to be useful. It tends to be modest and judges itself more strictly than others.

Its strength is **reliability** and the ability to improve things. The weaker side tends to be perfectionism, worries and a tendency to criticise itself.

What it can support in you

Grey can support moments when you want to tidy up both space and head. It fits a work desk, a wardrobe and a pantry.

With Virgo the strength is often in attention and order. Blue-grey can add **a little forgiveness**.

Shadow grey as protection from criticism

In the shadow, Virgo wears grey so that nobody can gossip about her. The colour becomes a shield against judgement.

Virgo is strict with herself and chooses grey from a certainty that nothing can be pointed out. Only joy is not there.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **take one thing that nobody will approve**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Mercury green and white.

green · white · yellow

Green and white give order and calm.

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Virgo as ascendant

When Virgo is your ascendant, you come across as neat, restrained and reliable. People see you as observant and sensible, sometimes even overly reserved.

Grey gives you a gentle and careful impression. Blue-grey and dove suit better than dark.

In everyday life

Put a grey pen or mug on your desk and do not correct anything about it.

*When you feel strict, try **leaving one thing imperfect** and looking at it in warm light.*

Libra (23 September – 22 October)

Your grey

silver · pink-grey · blue-grey

A grey that **suits you in gentleness and style**.

Libra is an air sign ruled by Venus. Grey suits it in elegant and balanced tones. Silver and pink-grey as **a cashmere scarf on a good coat**.

What Libra is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality cardinal · ruler Venus

Libra longs for **harmony**, beauty and justice. It is diplomatic, sociable and has a feel for aesthetics. It lives best in relationships in which it does not feel alone.

Its strength is **tact** and the ability to see both sides. The weaker side tends to be hesitation and a tendency to avoid conflict even when it would help.

What it can support in you

Grey can support moments when you want beauty and balance without shouting. It fits a flat, clothing and work.

With Libra the strength is often in taste and diplomacy. Grey can add **permission to stay with your own**.

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Shadow indecision hidden behind neutrality

In the shadow, Libra says "I don't mind" when she does mind. Grey becomes the colour that offends nobody and touches nothing.

Libra wants everything to match. So she postpones decisions and neutrality seems safe to her.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **choose one thing and leave it in place for ten days**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Venus green and white.

green · white · powder pink

Green and white add calm and reality.

Libra as ascendant

When Libra is your ascendant, you come across as elegant, pleasant and balanced. People like you for your tact, even if inside you take a long time to decide.

Grey gives you a pleasant and balanced impression. Pink-grey suits your manner best.

In everyday life

Try a grey scarf or a stone bowl on the table and notice what you like and what merely does not bother you.

*When everything seems too neutral, take **one thing in a darker grey** that has its own voice.*

Scorpio (23 October – 21 November)

Your grey

anthracite · graphite · slate

A grey that **allows depth without drama**.

Scorpio is a water sign linked with Mars and Pluto, depth and transformation. Grey is for it a stone, **under which something can be hidden**. Anthracite and slate may be closer to you than dove.

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What Scorpio is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality fixed · ruler Mars, in the newer view also Pluto

Scorpio is **intense**, deep and loyal. It feels strongly, but does not always show it. It dislikes superficiality and likes to get to what is hidden.

Its strength is **determination** and the ability to transform. The weaker side tends to be distrust, jealousy and a need to keep things under control.

What it can support in you

Grey can support moments when you want to be close, but in your own way. It suits a private detail.

With Scorpio the strength is often in depth and loyalty. Anthracite can add **calm after the storm**.

Shadow suspicious silence

In the shadow, Scorpio keeps silent because it does not believe anyone will understand. Grey serves as a lock.

After being hurt, Scorpios open up with difficulty. Grey means for them that nobody sees anything, and at the same time nobody knows anything.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you **take one thing out and put it in the light**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add black or dark wine.

black · wine · red

Black and wine give grey protection and mystery.

Scorpio as ascendant

When Scorpio is your ascendant, you come across as focused, mysterious and strong. People sense the intensity of your gaze and often feel that you know more than you say.

Grey gives you a calm depth behind a mysterious impression. Anthracite is the closest.

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In everyday life

Try having grey just for yourself in something nobody sees.

*When you want to withdraw, put on **grey jewellery under your clothes** and let it be your secret.*

Sagittarius (22 November – 21 December)

Your grey

stone · grey · sienna

Grey as **a road and a view from the mountains**.

Sagittarius is a fire sign linked with Jupiter, freedom and distances. Grey suits it as the colour of the road and stone paths. Stone and grey as **the colour of land you have not yet crossed**.

What Sagittarius is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality mutable · ruler Jupiter

Sagittarius is **optimistic**, open and free-spirited. It loves travel, new experiences and the search for meaning. It speaks honestly, sometimes a little too directly.

Its strength is **enthusiasm** and faith in a good outcome. The weaker side tends to be impatience with detail and a tendency to promise more than can be managed.

What it can support in you

Grey can support moments when you want to set out but stay calm. It fits a journey, the mountains and a café.

With Sagittarius the strength is often in optimism and momentum. Grey can add **the awareness of where you set out from**.

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Shadow reluctance to commit

In the shadow, Sagittarius wears neutral grey so as not to promise anything. The colour binds nobody and leaves nothing behind.

Sagittarians love freedom and grey is for them a colour without promise. But then nobody knows what they want.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to have **one thing you will return to**, for example a stone or a mug.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Jupiter blue or gold.

blue · gold · green

Blue and gold give grey reach and momentum.

Sagittarius as ascendant

When Sagittarius is your ascendant, you come across as open, jovial and adventurous. People see you as someone with a wide outlook and an appetite for discovery.

Grey gives you a friendly and open impression. Stone suits more than dark.

In everyday life

Take a grey scarf or stone on the road and put it in the same place after you return.

*When something feels tight, try **looking to see whether it is only closeness**.*

Capricorn (22 December – 19 January)

Your grey

graphite · slate · grey

A grey that **lets you be firm and calm**.

Capricorn is an earth sign linked with Saturn, responsibility and perseverance. Grey suits it naturally, as the colour of stone and metal, **proven by long years**. Graphite and slate add a maturity that can warm.

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What Capricorn is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality cardinal · ruler Saturn

Capricorn is **responsible**, goal-oriented and disciplined. It likes to build and is not afraid of a long road. It has a dry sense of humour and shows it only to those it trusts.

Its strength is **perseverance** and the ability to see things through. The weaker side tends to be strictness with itself, reserve and a tendency to put joy off until later.

What it can support in you

Grey can support moments when you want to lay a firm foundation. It fits an office, a house and long-term plans.

With Capricorn the strength is often in order and perseverance. Graphite can add **a willingness to rest**.

Shadow grey duty without joy

In the shadow, Capricorn makes a duty of everything. Grey becomes the colour of work one cannot leave.

Capricorn fears that if it rested, it would achieve nothing. Then even pleasures are just another task.

The colour can help you here too. It can help you **find one place where nothing gets improved**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Saturn black and cream.

black · cream · brown

Black and cream give grey weight and warmth.

Capricorn as ascendant

When Capricorn is your ascendant, you come across as serious, mature and reserved. People may see you as older than you are, and only later discover how funny you are.

Grey gives you a trustworthy and calm impression. Graphite works best.

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In everyday life

Put a grey lining or button on serious clothing.

*When you are too strict, try to **look at a grey thing and not improve anything**.*

Aquarius (20 January – 18 February)

Your grey

silver · blue-grey · sky blue

Grey as **an unexpected idea** among colours.

Aquarius is an air sign linked with Saturn and Uranus, independence and ideas. Grey belongs to it as an inconspicuous choice that surprises. Silver next to light blue looks like **the colour of a calm future**.

What Aquarius is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality fixed · ruler Saturn, in the newer view also Uranus

Aquarius is **independent**, original and idealistic. It is interested in ideas, humanity and the future. It wants to go its own way and does not like adapting to expectations.

Its strength is **perspective** and the ability to come up with new things. The weaker side tends to be distance from feelings and a tendency to withdraw when there is too much closeness.

What it can support in you

Grey can support moments when you want something unusual, but with calm. It fits a poster, a logo and clothing.

With Aquarius the strength is often in originality and perspective. Grey can add **firm ground under ideas**.

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Shadow disconnecting from the world

In the shadow, Aquarius withdraws into grey and stops taking part. Solitude poses as independence.

Aquarians like to keep a detached view and grey makes that easy for them. Only then the body is alone and nobody knows its needs.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you **take something rough and natural in your hand** and just notice it for a while.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add a cool blue or silver.

sky blue · silver · white

Blue and silver give grey clarity and distance.

Aquarius as ascendant

When Aquarius is your ascendant, you come across as independent, a little unusual and friendly. People see you as an original personality who keeps their own space.

Grey gives you an unexpected and friendly impression. Silver and blue-grey are the closest.

In everyday life

Try putting one grey thing in your bag for a week and not explaining it.

*When everything seems too neutral to you, try **telling yourself what you like about it**.*

Pisces (19 February – 20 March)

Your grey

dove · pink-grey · violet-grey

Grey as **mist over water**.

Pisces is a water sign linked with Jupiter and Neptune, feeling and imagination. Grey can give it soft boundaries. Dove and violet-grey may remind you of **dawn over the sea**.

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What Pisces is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality mutable · ruler Jupiter, in the newer view also Neptune

Pisces is **empathic**, intuitive and dreamy. It picks up the moods around it and often has a rich imagination. It frequently has a bond with art, music and spirituality.

Its strength is **compassion** and creative fantasy. The weaker side tends to be merging with other people's feelings, escaping into dreams and difficulty setting boundaries.

What it can support in you

Grey can support moments when you need to anchor yourself. It fits a bedroom, a picture and a scent.

With Pisces the strength is often in empathy and imagination. Grey can add **a willingness to stand firm even in a current**.

Shadow mist you cannot step out of

In the shadow, Pisces gets lost in grey and cannot tell what is its own and what is someone else's. The mist becomes a home.

Pisces are sensitive and easily take on someone else's atmosphere. Grey gives them comfort, but not direction.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you **have one thing at home that you chose yourself**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add grey with blue or green.

blue · green · cream

Blue and green give grey water and soil.

Pisces as ascendant

When Pisces is your ascendant, you come across as gentle, dreamy and adaptable. People like to project their wishes onto you and tend to be kind to you.

Grey gives you a soft and calm impression. Dove and violet-grey are the closest.

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In everyday life

In the evening light a candle, take a grey stone and write three sentences about your day.

*When you feel like running away, take **a grey thing firmly in your hand** and return to the room.*

FOR A DEEPER LOOK

- **Seasons**

Grey is the colour of autumn and winter dusk. Mist, wet stone and a low sky. Summer almost drowns it out with green and light. Ask yourself when you reach for it.

- **Time of day**

Morning and late afternoon tend to be grey when it dawns or darkens. Midday tends to be too sharp for neutral tones and they lose subtlety.

- **Years of life**

Saturn orbits the Sun in roughly 29 years. Astrology speaks of its returns at about 29 and 58 and reads them as times when a person asks what is truly their own. Grey may feel close to you in those years as a reminder of calm, or on the contrary foreign, like a farewell to a role that only adapted. Both are natural. Research by Palmer and Schloss (2010) also reports that we like colours according to the things and experiences we link with them. Astrology does not rule that out, it merely offers another view.

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Colour for your website and business

Yes, mainly where you sell precision, calm and expertise. Grey promises order, but can easily feel impersonal.

In business, grey is a colour that **does not disturb**, but at the same time carries a label of austerity. It can look elegant, technical, unobtrusive and also impersonal. That is why it is good to know what you are promising before you let it into your logo, website or advert.

On its own it **does not attract customers** like a magnet, though. It can help create **a calm impression**, but what still decides is mainly **what you sell**, **to whom** and **how well** it all works together.

What we are telling the customer

Grey can say, for example

"It's clear." "It's professional." "I'm not intruding." "You can rely on it."

- **Elegance.** Light and silver can look refined when well executed.
- **Technology and expertise.** Grey links to metal, stone, tools and technical surroundings.
- **Calm.** A neutral base lets the content stand out and distracts from nothing.
- **Neutrality.** It fits where you do not want to favour either side.
- **Coolness.** Without a warm companion it can feel impersonal.

Depending on the shade it also feels different. Silver and dove are **light and elegant**, slate and graphite **serious and technical**, warm stone **calm and natural**.

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Simple tips

- **Add one lively accent**
  Grey can carry one rich colour well. Keep large areas calm.
- **Show real photographs**
  A specific photograph and a clear description of the service say more than another dark stripe.
- **Shade by role**
  Graphite for expertise, silver for elegance, warm grey-beige for friendliness.
- **Legibility**
  Light grey lettering on white is hard to read. Use a darker shade.
- **Cultural context**
  In England grey friars, in Japan grey as taste, in Wales slate. Before you go out into the world, find out what grey means at home and where you are heading.
- **Colour blindness**
  About 1 in 12 men has difficulty telling red from green. Grey and brown may blend for them. Do not rely on shade alone, add shape or text.

Professions where it is a Yes

The rule is simple. When you sell precision, calm or room for content, grey can help you.

Art, photography and original work

A grey background can let a work, a photograph or a product stand out. That suits a gallery, a photographer or an author's brand. But take care that inconspicuousness does not become "I didn't notice what you offer".

Craft, engineering and professional services

Grey can link to metal, stone, tools or a technical surrounding. A grey logo alone does not prove professionalism, though. That still needs real work.

Architecture and interior design

A neutral grey gives space to the materials, the light and the clients' colour. It needs a warm companion, though, so that the portfolio does not feel like a catalogue.

Office and consulting services

Grey can look trustworthy, but also easily anonymous. Add human photographs, real names and one colour accent.

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Professions where it is a No

This is not a ban for whole fields. What decides is the interplay of colour, text, photographs and setting.

- **Care and personal services.** If you want to offer human acceptance, a cold grey alone can feel too impersonal.
- **Children's and playful projects.** The variety you want to offer may be missing.
- **Celebrations and lively social events.** Large grey areas can create a more serious impression.
- **Long texts.** Light grey lettering on white can be hard to read.
- **Presenting colour-sensitive products.** Check whether the surrounding shade changes their perceived look.

Try poorly lit waiting rooms and corridors first with a smaller amount of other dark surfaces.

Before you send it out into the world

Show the design to a woman who does not know your offer and ask "What would you expect from such a place or service?" **Is the offer visible, or mainly the grey?** Her answer may tell you more than the general rule that grey means professionalism.

A question for you

“What should your customer feel first when she looks at your website?”

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Examples from the market

You know grey from gadgets, games and shoes. Here are **a few examples** that show what it can do.

- **Nintendo Game Boy (games)**
  The handheld console was released in Japan on 21 April 1989 and in North America on 31 July 1989. The original model has a grey plastic body and the display shows four shades of grey-green. Grey here carries simplicity.

- **Nintendo NES (games)**
  The console went on test sale in New York in North America on 18 October 1985 and nationwide on 27 September 1986. The designers Lance Barr and Don James chose a two-tone grey finish with a black stripe and red lettering. Grey was to set the console apart from others and show it as consumer electronics, not a toy.

- **Apple iPhone 5s (phones)**
  The phone was introduced on 10 September 2013 in three finishes. For the first time came the space gray shade, which replaced black with slate accents. Grey here carries an impression of restraint.

- **New Balance (footwear)**
  The 990 model came in 1982 as the brand's first premium running shoe. Grey has been its signature since the eighties. According to the brand's story, the shoe in it copes better with dirt.

What they have in common is that grey carries a simple message. **Reliably, soberly, for use.** And it mostly does not outweigh what is around it.

Colours in business are not law. Studies are mixed and a lot depends on context, on customers and on how consistent the brand is. Take it as an idea to test, not as a rule. The brand examples are publicly known and the facts about them come from public sources.

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Different colour combinations

Grey + red

How it feels

A stone house and a red roof. Red gives grey life and grey gives red calm. Together they look like brick and stone.

When it suits

When you want **strength with calm**.

Specific shades



grey + red
strikingly



graphite + burgundy
deeply



silver + coral
freshly



slate + scarlet
elegantly



dove + brick
earthily

In practice

A grey coat and a red scarf. A grey wall and a red picture.

Watch out

Two strong colours pull against each other. Give one of them **more space**.

Grey + orange

How it feels

Ash and fire. Orange warms grey up and grey calms orange. Together they look modern and friendly.

When it suits

When you want **warmth with distance**.

Specific shades



grey + orange
radiantly



graphite + terracotta
richly



silver + apricot
softly



slate + pumpkin
daringly



dove + rust
subduedly

In practice

A grey sofa with an orange cushion. A grey bag and an orange scarf.

Watch out

Too much orange next to grey shouts. Try to **mute it with something earthier**.

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Grey + yellow

How it feels

Mist and sun. Yellow lights grey up and grey gives yellow calm. Together they look fresh, like an autumn day with a ray of sun.

When it suits

When you want **cheerful restraint**.

Specific shades



grey + yellow
cheerfully



graphite + ochre
golden



silver + butter
springlike



slate + lemon
radiantly



dove + mustard
subduedly

In practice

A grey coat and a yellow scarf. A grey wall and a yellow vase.

Watch out

At equal saturation the colours pull against each other. Keep yellow **as an accent**.

Grey + green

How it feels

Stone and moss. Green and grey are a natural pair. Rock, moss, an olive tree, nobody blinks at that.

When it suits

When you want **a natural and calm impression**.

Specific shades



grey + green
naturally



graphite + bottle green
woodland



silver + mint
freshly



slate + emerald
earthily



dove + sage
quietly

In practice

A green plant on a grey table. Sage and grey in a living room.

Watch out

A sharp green next to a cold grey sounds loud. **Mute** the green.

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Grey + blue

How it feels

Mist over water. Blue cools grey and grey quietens blue. Together they feel calm, but easily cold.

When it suits

When you want **calm and airiness**.

Specific shades


grey + blue
calmly


graphite + dark blue
deeply


silver + sky
airily


slate + cobalt
freshly


dove + denim
soberly

In practice

A blue jumper and grey trousers. A light blue wall and grey furniture.

Watch out

Both are cold. Without warmth the whole can feel **cold**.

Grey + indigo

How it feels

Dusk. Indigo gives grey depth and grey gives indigo light. Together they recall an evening sky.

When it suits

When you want **depth without heaviness**.

Specific shades


grey + indigo
at dusk


graphite + ink
deeply


silver + twilight blue
firmly


slate + ultramarine
dramatically


dove + grey-indigo
soberly

In practice

An indigo coat and a grey scarf. Navy and grey in an office.

Watch out

Dark and dark blend. Add **a light colour**.

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Grey + violet

How it feels

Mist with lavender. Purple gives grey dreaminess and grey gives purple calm. Together they feel quiet and elegant.

When it suits

When you want **softness and depth**.

Specific shades


grey + purple
dreamily


graphite + plum
mysteriously


silver + lavender
deeply


slate + orchid
richly


dove + grey-violet
dustily

In practice

Lavender and dove on cushions. Grey-violet and silver in jewellery.

Watch out

A too cold and veiled whole. Add **a warm colour**.

Grey + pink

How it feels

Stone and peony. Pink softens grey and grey calms pink. Together they feel tasteful, not sweet.

When it suits

When you want **elegance without sweetness**.

Specific shades


grey + pink
soberly


graphite + raspberry
elegantly


silver + powder
lightly


slate + fuchsia
modernly


dove + old rose
quietly

In practice

A grey coat and a pink scarf. A grey wall and an old-rose throw.

Watch out

A cold grey with a sharp pink is **unforgiving**. Try a warmer material.

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Grey + brown

How it feels

Stone and wood. Brown warms grey and grey lightens brown. Together they feel natural and calm.

When it suits

When you want **warmth and stability**.

Specific shades



grey + brown
naturally



graphite + chocolate
calmly



silver + beige
earthily



slate + caramel
soberly



dove + linen
subduedly

In practice

A grey sofa and a wooden table. A grey jumper and brown boots.

Watch out

Two neutral colours can merge. Add **a lively colour**.

Grey + white

How it feels

A clean sheet. White brightens grey and gives it space. Together they feel fresh and calm.

When it suits

When you want **purity and lightness**.

Specific shades



grey + white
cleanly



graphite + ivory
elegantly



silver + snow
freshly



slate + milk
strikingly



dove + bone
gently

In practice

A white kitchen with a grey worktop. A white shirt and grey trousers.

Watch out

Too much white and grey can feel **clinical**. Add wood or linen.

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Grey + black

How it feels

Graphic contrast. Black makes grey a deep colour. Together they look serious and elegant.

When it suits

When you want **expression and elegance**.

Specific shades


grey + black
dramatically


graphite + charcoal
deeply


silver + anthracite
soberly


slate + ink black
elegantly


dove + soot
discreetly

In practice

A black jacket and a grey jumper. A blackboard and grey chalk.

Watch out

Two dark colours tend to be heavy. Add **white or cream**.

Grey + gold

How it feels

Silver and gold. Gold highlights grey and gives it shine. Together they look festive and sober at once.

When it suits

When you want **celebration without heaviness**.

Specific shades


grey + gold
festively


graphite + antique gold
richly


silver + champagne
gently


slate + rich gold
radiantly


dove + matte gold
subduedly

In practice

Gold jewellery on a grey jumper. Grey packaging with gold lettering.

Watch out

In excess gold drowns out calm and the space recalls **a shop window**.

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A SIMPLE RULE

- When you want to **warm** grey, add **ochre**, **brown**, **wood** or **cream**.
- When you want to **bring it to life**, add **green**, **yellow** or **pink**.
- When you want to **deepen** it, **indigo**, **dark blue** or **black** will help.
- When you want to **emphasise** it, add **gold**, **red** or **white**.

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